Worn Gundidj

SOCIAL AND EMOTIONAL WELLBEING



We ndis

Registered NDIS Provider

NDIS Provider Number: 4050163252

WORN GUNDIDJ

Social & Emotional Wellbeing Participant Handbook

A culturally safe, strengths-based guide to your SEWB journey with Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative.

Welcome to Worn Gundidj.

This handbook is for people receiving Social and Emotional Wellbeing (SEWB) support from Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative.

It explains what you can expect from us, your rights, how we work, how we keep you safe, and how you can shape your own wellbeing and healing journey.

Our SEWB approach recognises that wellbeing is not only about an individual's mental health. It is holistic and interconnected, including connection to Country, culture, family and kinship, community, spirituality and ancestors, mind and emotions, and physical wellbeing.

Your strengths, identity, relationships, aspirations, and sense of belonging matter.

You do not have to read this handbook all at once.

We can yarn through it with you, explain it in plain language, provide accessible formats, arrange an interpreter, or involve a family member, Elder, advocate or support person if you want.

Participant name:	
Participant contact details:	
Date provided:	
Worker Details	Name: Phone: Email:

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Our commitment to you

- ★ We will listen to you and believe your experience.
- ★ We will respect your identity, culture, language, family, kinship and beliefs.
- ★ We will support your right to self-determination and choice.
- ★ We will work at your pace and in places where you feel safe and comfortable.
- ★ We will build on strengths, resilience, hope, connection and capability.
- ★ We will recognise the importance of healing, grief, loss and trauma without defining you by them.
- ★ We will support connection to Country, culture, community and family where you want this.
- ★ We will involve Elders, respected people, family and significant others when you choose and where appropriate.
- ★ We will be honest about what we can and cannot provide, and connect you with other supports when needed.
- ★ We will protect your privacy and explain when information may need to be shared for safety or legal reasons.
- ★ We will take concerns, complaints and cultural safety issues seriously and learn from your feedback.

1. Who we are

Worn Gundidj was established in south-west Victoria on the belief that Aboriginal people should lead solutions for their own communities. From the beginning, our purpose has been to protect Culture, strengthen self-determination and create meaningful opportunities for current and future generations.

For more than three decades, we have walked alongside community, listening deeply, learning continuously and leading with care. Our work spans employment, education, wellbeing and cultural preservation, with every initiative grounded in connection, purpose and respect for Country. Guided by Elders, community knowledge and strong partnerships, we continue to support grassroots action that creates lasting change.

Today, Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative Ltd is an Aboriginal community-controlled co-operative based in Warrnambool, delivering services across south-west Victoria. Operating continuously since 1994, Worn Gundidj is governed by a community-based Board and remains accountable to the people and communities we serve.

We are a proud Aboriginal-led organisation committed to protecting and promoting Culture, People and Place.

As cultural custodians of south-west Victoria, we support Aboriginal, Torres Strait Islander and non-Indigenous communities through employment, education and enterprise.

Worn Gundidj provides a range of services and can connect people across programs when this supports their needs and goals. This handbook focuses specifically on Social and Emotional Wellbeing support and how we work with Community Members on their wellbeing and healing journey.

2. What Social & Emotional Wellbeing means.

SEWB is a holistic way of understanding wellbeing. It includes mental health, but does not reduce wellbeing to symptoms or diagnosis. It recognises the relationships between people, family and kinship, community, culture, country, spirituality, physical wellbeing, social and historical circumstances.

The Social, Emotional, Wellbeing Framework (**Balit Murrup**) identifies seven interconnected dimensions:

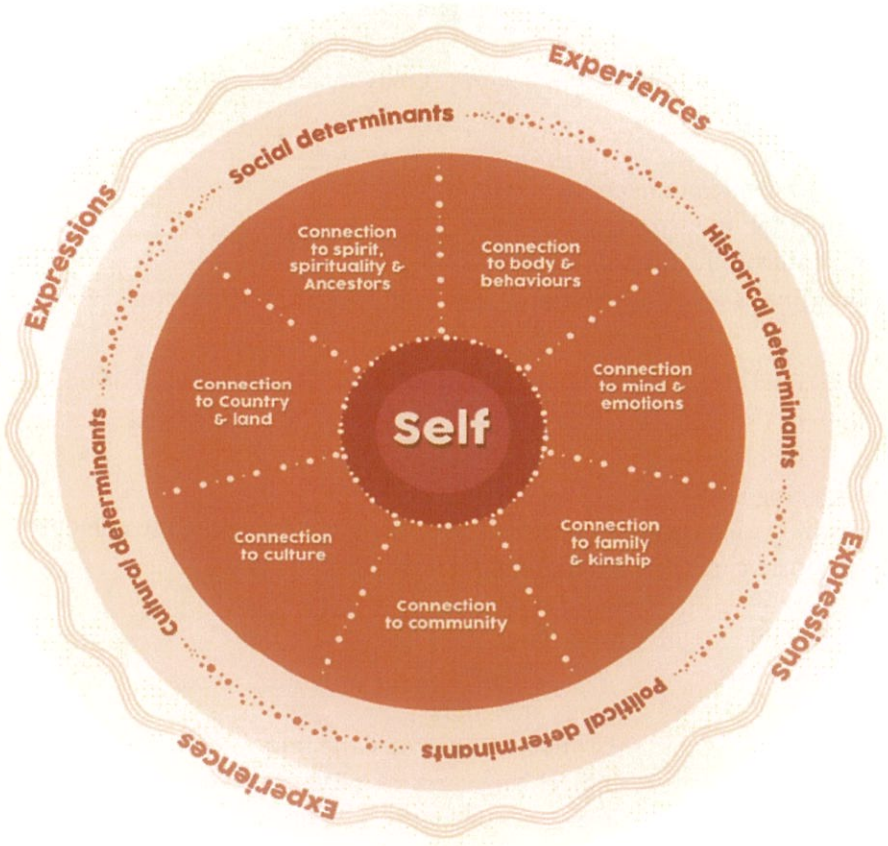
- ★ Connection to spirit, spirituality and ancestors
- ★ Connection to land/Country
- ★ Connection to culture
- ★ Connection to community
- ★ Connection to family and kinship
- ★ Connection to mind and emotions
- ★ Connection to body and behaviors.

The model also recognises the influence of social, political, historical and cultural determinants.

This means your support may include practical, emotional, cultural, social and connection-focused goals - not only clinical or individual goals.

Good support should help you feel heard rather than talked over; respected rather than judged; safe rather than threatened; connected rather than isolated; supported rather than controlled; hopeful rather than defined by problems; able to make choices rather than having choices made for you; proud of your identity, strengths and connections; and able to build skills and supports that remain useful beyond the service.

If your experience does not feel like this, please tell us. Your feedback is part of how we improve.



SEWB Diagram adapted from Gee et al., (2014)

3. Your SEWB rights

- ★ You have the right to be treated with dignity, respect and kindness.
- ★ You have the right to have your culture and identity respected and supported.
- ★ You have the right to make your own decisions and be supported to make informed choices and to receive information in a way you understand.
- ★ You have the right to have time to think, yarn, ask questions and involve people you trust.
- ★ You have the right to privacy and confidentiality, with clear explanations of limits. This includes the involvment of family, kin, Elders, advocates or other support people.
- ★ You have the right to say no, change your mind and withdraw consent without penalty, subject to lawful safety or reporting obligations.
- ★ You have the right to be free from racism, discrimination, violence, abuse, neglect, exploitation and harassment.
- ★ You have the right to an advocate and to provide feedback without fear of losing your support.
- ★ You can ask for an Aboriginal worker, worker of a particular gender, or other culturally appropriate arrangement where possible.
- ★ You have the right to have Sorry Business and cultural obligations recognised in how supports are scheduled.

4. First Peoples practice: what cultural safety looks like

Cultural safety is more than acknowledging culture. It means the service listens, responds respectfully, and avoids practices that make you feel unsafe, stereotyped, judged, excluded or required to justify who you are. For Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples, we recognise that connection to Country, culture, family and community can be central to wellbeing. We will ask what matters to you rather than assuming what culture means for you.

You do not have to disclose cultural information you do not want to share. Your identity, connections and stories belong to you. We will not require you to prove your Aboriginality to receive Worn Gundidj services.

Where appropriate and with your agreement, support may include:

- ★ Cultural strengthening,
- ★ Connection to Country,
- ★ Family tracing or kinship connection,
- ★ Yarning with an Elder or respected person,
- ★ Community activities, cultural groups,
- ★ or links to Aboriginal-specific services.

5. Self-determination and supported decision-making

Your life is yours to lead. Our role is to support you to understand choices, risks and opportunities; not to take over decisions that belong to you.

Informed decision-making means we:

- ★ Provide information and ensure you understand this before you need to decide.
- ★ We use language and communication methods that work for you.
- ★ Give you enough time.
- ★ Support you to involve people you trust.
- ★ Explain realistic options.
- ★ Respect your will, preferences, values and goals.

We will support you to build confidence and skills so you can make more decisions for yourself.

Dignity of risk means you can make choices that carry risk. Where a decision involves significant risk, we will talk it through with you honestly, plan how to reduce the risk, and record the agreed approach.

6. Your SEWB Intake and Healing Journey Plan

Our initial conversations are not about fitting you into a category or making assumptions about your experiences. They are about getting to know you as a whole person, understanding what is happening in your life, what strengths and supports you already have, what has helped in the past, and what matters most to you now and into the future. Through a holistic SEWB intake assessment, we work together to explore the areas of your life that you feel are important, which may include family, kinship, community, Mob, Country and cultural connections; housing, education and employment; physical health; social and emotional wellbeing; grief, loss and trauma; experiences of racism or discrimination; relationships and support networks; personal strengths, interests and aspirations; safety concerns; and your short, medium and long term goals. You do not need to discuss everything at once. The process is guided by your readiness, choices and priorities. The information gathered through the intake helps inform your SEWB Healing Journey Plan, which is developed collaboratively with you and reflects your strengths, values, goals and aspirations. The plan may identify what you would like to change or strengthen, the people, places, cultural connections and activities that support your wellbeing, practical actions to help achieve your goals, and the roles of both you and your support team. It can also include strategies that help you stay safe and well, early signs that you may be becoming overwhelmed, crisis and escalation arrangements where required, and agreed review timeframes. Recognising that healing, growth and recovery are not always linear, your Healing Journey Plan remains flexible and can be reviewed and updated as your circumstances, needs and priorities change.

8. Healing, trauma-informed support and recovery

We recognise that people may carry the effects of personal, family, community and historical trauma. We will not assume that trauma explains everything about you, and we will not require you to retell painful experiences simply to receive support.

A trauma-informed approach means paying attention to safety, trust, choice, control, relationships, strengths and the possible effects of trauma. Healing may include cultural, spiritual, family, community, practical and therapeutic pathways, depending on what you want and what is appropriate.

Where you are distressed, we will aim to help you feel safe and regulated first; listen without judgement; work at your pace; focus on what you can manage now; provide practical help; support connection to people, culture, Country and community where wanted; coordinate with other services; and support recovery, hope, dignity and future goals.

9. Yarning and relationship

Relationships are central to good SEWB practice. We aim to create environments that are welcoming, comfortable and respectful. Depending on the program and your preferences, support may occur at a Worn Gundidj site, in the community, during a practical activity, through outreach, or another agreed setting. You can take your time. You can ask questions, pause, change the subject or bring someone with you. We will explain professional boundaries and confidentiality clearly, particularly where a worker already knows you, your social or kinship connects.

10. Family, kinship, Elders and Community

Family and kinship can be central to wellbeing and decision-making. You decide who you regard as family or kin and who you want involved. With your agreement and under your direction, we will work alongside family members, Elders, respected people, community members or other support persons. We will consider cultural authority and your wishes about who should be involved.

Sometimes family or community involvement is not safe or not wanted. We will respect this and work with you to identify safer supports.

11. Culture, Country, Spirituality and Connection

Your SEWB plan can include goals related to returning too or spending time on Country; cultural activities, language or cultural learning; connecting with Mob or family; community events and groups; Elders and cultural mentors; spirituality, faith or connection to ancestors where this is meaningful to you; cultural identity, pride and belonging; and grief, Sorry Business and cultural obligations.
We will not assume that all Aboriginal people have the same culture, beliefs, Country or preferences. Aboriginal communities and peoples are diverse. We will ask you what is right for you.

12. Mental health, Alcohol and Other Drugs

SEWB support can include conversations about mental health, emotional wellbeing, or substance misuse concerns. These areas may be connected with housing, family relationships, grief, trauma, financial stress, justice involvement, physical health and other circumstances.
You will be treated as a whole person, not as a diagnosis or a substance-use history. Where specialist treatment is needed, we will support referral and coordination with appropriate services.
If you are in immediate danger or need urgent medical help, call 000.
If you want Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander crisis support, 13YARN is available 24/7 on 13 92 76.

13. Safety, violence, abuse, neglect and exploitation

Worn Gundidj has zero tolerance for violence, abuse, neglect and exploitation.
Abuse can be physical, sexual, emotional, financial, cultural or spiritual. Neglect includes failing to provide care or support that should have been provided.
Tell us if you feel unsafe, including if the concern involves a worker, another participant, a family member, another service, or someone else. You can speak with any worker or manager, use the feedback process, or contact an external body directly. **If there is immediate danger, call 000.** We will prioritise your safety and wellbeing, take concerns seriously, and report matters to authorities when required by law.

14. Child and family safety

Where children are involved, Worn Gundidj works within its child-safe, family violence and information-sharing responsibilities. The intake form asks about children in your care, whether you and your children are safe to go home, and whether there are relevant orders or concerns. Some information may need to be shared without consent where the law requires it or where this is necessary to assess or manage serious safety risks. We will explain this wherever it is safe and lawful to do so.

15. Privacy, confidentiality and consent

Your information belongs to you. We collect information needed to provide safe and appropriate services and manage our legal, quality and funding responsibilities.

- ★ Consent means you agree freely, with enough information to understand what you agree too.
- ★ You can ask questions before consenting, take time to decide, involve a support person or advocate, say no, and withdraw consent at any time, subject to lawful safety or reporting obligations.
- ★ Information may be shared without consent in limited circumstances, including where required by law or where necessary to address serious safety risks.

16. Advocates and support people

You have the right to an advocate, family member, Elder, friend or support person as you engage on your healing journey with Worn Gundidj. An advocate can help you understand your rights, communicate what you want, prepare for meetings and provide feedback about your experience.
You choose who supports you. If you want an independent advocate but do not have one, Worn Gundidj can help you find an advocacy service.

17. Accessibility and communication

You should be able to understand information about your supports.
Please ask for information to be provided in:

- ★ Easy Read, large print
- ★ Information to be read aloud,
- ★ The inclusion of an interpreter, Auslan translator, communication assistance, or another reasonable adjustment.

We can also work with your existing communication aids or systems. Tell us what helps you communicate and what makes appointments easier or safer.

18. Worker standards and boundaries

- ★ Workers are expected to act respectfully, honestly, safely and within their role.
- ★ Worn Gundidj workers must meet relevant screening, induction, training and qualification requirements for their roles.
- ★ You can ask to see worker identification.
- ★ You can ask for a different worker, including based on gender or cultural preference, and you do not need to justify your request.
- ★ Workers must maintain professional boundaries.
- ★ They must not misuse their role, pressure you, accept inappropriate benefits, or make decisions about your support for their own interests.

19. Money, property and conflicts of interest

Your money and belongings are yours. Workers have strict limits around handling money, gifts, property, banking information and personal benefits. A conflict of interest can occur when personal or organisational interests could improperly influence a decision affecting you. Conflicts must be declared and actively managed. **You are never required to choose Worn Gundidj simply because you receive another service from Worn Gundidj.**

20. Incidents and emergencies

An incident is something that has harmed, or could have caused harm to,you or another person. Near misses can also be recorded because learning from them can prevent future harm.
After an incident we will make people safe and arrange urgent assistance if needed; report and record the incident; explain what happened and what we are doing subject to privacy and legal requirements; investigate and identify actions to reduce recurrence; and review what was learned and make improvements. **For emergencies, call 000. For bushfire, flood and other emergency warnings, follow current local emergency directions.**

21. Feedback, complaints and cultural safety concerns

You have the right to complain, give feedback, make a suggestion, or tell us that something went well. Complaints can be about a worker, service, decision, cultural safety, privacy, communication, discrimination, safety or anything else that matters to you.

How to provide feedback:

- ★ Tell the worker supporting you.
- ★ Ask to speak with a manager.
- ★ Phone: (03) 5561 5315
- ★ Email feedback@worngundidj.org.au
- ★ Make a complaint in writing or anonymously where available
- ★ Or ask an advocate, family member, Elder or support person to help.

Providing feedback will not result in a loss of support.

22. Changing, cancelling or rescheduling support

Life happens and plans change. Tell us as early as you can if you need to change or cancel a support session. We will consider cultural obligations, emergencies, illness and other circumstances and aim to reschedule where possible. The organisational NDIS Participant Handbook sets out the current cancellation arrangements for NDIS-funded supports. Where this SEWB service is NDIS-funded *(such as Cultural Strengthening)*, the service agreement and current NDIS rules apply to the specific support.

23. Leaving, transitioning and returning

You can choose to leave a service. Where appropriate, we will work with you on a transition plan so important supports are not simply stopped. With your consent, we can coordinate with another provider and share information needed for a safe transition.
If you return to Worn Gundidj later, we will look at your current circumstances and support needs rather than assuming nothing has changed.

24. Quality, accountability and continuous improvement

Quality is not only about compliance. It is about whether people experience services that are safe, effective, connected and person-centred, and whether the organisation listens, learns and Grows.
Worn Gundidj will use participant feedback, complaints, incidents, service information, supervision, workforce learning and governance processes to identify improvements. We will seek to involve people who use services in understanding what is working and what needs to change.

For SEWB, quality also means asking whether our practice is culturally safe, strengths-based, trauma-informed, connected, respectful of self-determination, and responsive to family, community and Country where these matter to the participant.

25. Words we use

- **SEWB**: *As identified in **Balit Murrup** the Social Emotional Wellbeing Framework is a holistic, interconnected understanding of wellbeing.*
- **Self-determination**: *Your right to make decisions about your life, identity, community and wellbeing.*
- **Supported decision-making**: *Receiving the support you need to make your own decisions rather than having decisions made for you.*
- **Cultural safety:** *Practice that respects identity and avoids racism, exclusion, stereotyping and cultural harm.*
- **Kinship:** *Family and relationship systems that may extend beyond a household or Western definitions of family.*
- **Country:** *A living connection to land, waters, people, culture, ancestors and place; what Country means is determined by the person and community.*
- **Sorry Business**: *Cultural practices and obligations associated with death, mourning and grief.*
- **Advocate:** *An independent person who supports you to understand and exercise your rights.*
- **Trauma-informed:** *An approach that considers the effects of trauma and prioritises safety, trust, choice, control and strengths.*
- **Strengths-based:** *Focusing on capabilities, resources, relationships, resilience and hopes, not only problems.*
- **NDIS:** *National Disability Insurance Scheme.*
- **NDIA:** *National Disability Insurance Agency.*
- **NDIS Commission:** *NDIS Quality and Safeguards Commission, the independent regulator of NDIS providers and workers.*

Participant acknowledgement

Signing this page confirms that you have received the handbook and had the opportunity to have it explained in a way you understand. It does not replace your service agreement and does not remove any of your rights.

Participant name: _____

Preferred name: _____

Support person/Carer (if applicable): _____

SEWB Worker: _____

Date provided: ____/_____ /____

Date discussed: _____/_____ /____

Format provided: [ ] Standard [ ] Easy Read [ ] Large print [ ] Read aloud [ ] Interpreter [ ] Auslan [ ] Other

- ❑ I understand I can ask questions, request changes or adjustments, use an advocate, give feedback and make a complaint at any time. *(Please tick the box.)*

Participant/Carer signature: _____ Date: ____/____ /____

SEWB Worker signature: _____ Date: ____/_____ /____

Emergency Contacts & Supports

Social & Emotional Wellbeing Team - Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative

1-3 Rooneys Rd, Warrnambool VIC 3280 | Phone **(03) 5561 5315**

In immediate danger or someone is hurt? Call 000 or go to the Emergency Department, Warrnambool Base Hospital, Ryot Street.

CRISIS SUPPORT - 24 HOURS, 7 DAYS

SWH Mental Health Triage	**1800 808 284**	Local mental health crisis assessment and advice
13YARN	**13 92 76**	Yarn with an Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander Crisis Supporter
Yarning SafeNStrong (VAHS)	**1800 959 563**	Free Aboriginal counselling line
Lifeline	**13 11 14**	Crisis support and suicide prevention
Suicide Call Back Service	**1300 659 467**	Counselling for anyone affected by suicide
Nurse On Call	**1300 60 60 24**	Health advice from a registered nurse

ABORIGINAL SERVICES (business hours)

Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-op 1-3 Rooneys Rd	**03 5561 5315**
Gunditjmara Aboriginal Co-op	03 5559 1234
Gunditjmara (SEWB, mental health, youth)	03 5562 1452
Gunditjmara Health Clinic	03 5564 3344
Kirrae Health Service (Purnim)	03 5567 1270

LOCAL MENTAL HEALTH & PSYCHOSOCIAL

headspace Warrnambool (12-25) 210 Timor St. Mon-Fri 9-5, Tue/Wed to 7pm	1300 276 749
Wellways Mental Health & Wellbeing Hub 505 Raglan Pde	03 5560 3000
Wellways psychosocial navigation	03 4333 0251
Mind Australia (Step Thru Care)	1300 286 463
SWH Primary Mental Health Team	03 5561 9100
Warrnambool Community Health	03 5563 4000
Warrnambool Urgent Care Clinic 3 Banyan St	03 9975 8403

AFTER-HOURS HELPLINES (24/7)

Alcohol & drugs - DirectLine	**1800 888 236**
Family Drug & Gambling Helpline	1300 660 068
Family violence - Safe Steps	**1800 015 188**
1800RESPECT	1800 737 732
Homelessness / crisis housing	**1800 825 955**
Kids Helpline (5-25)	1800 55 1800
MensLine Australia	1300 78 99 78
After Hours GP Helpline	1800 022 222
Child Protection After Hours	13 12 78
Rainbow Door (LGBTIQA+, check hours)	1800 729 367

FAMILY VIOLENCE & WOMEN'S SUPPORT

Emma House (SAFV Centre) Women & children. Counselling, legal, safety planning. Mon-Fri 9-5	**1800 366 238**
The Orange Door Warrnambool Family violence & family support	**1800 271 180**
South Western CASA Sexual assault support. After hours 1800 806 292	03 5564 4144
Gunditjmara Co-op Aboriginal women & children	03 5562 1452
Djirra Aboriginal women's legal & support	1800 105 303

MY PEOPLE

My SEWB worker _____

Someone I trust _____

My GP _____

Someone I trust _____

Local Aboriginal services close after hours - call 13YARN, Yarning SafeNStrong or SWH Triage instead. From a mobile, some 1800 lines may ask you to request a call back. Numbers checked September 2026; confirm before relying on them.

Acknowledgement of Country. Worn Gundidj acknowledges the Gunditjmara Peoples, on whose unceded lands we work, and pays respect to Elders past, present and emerging.